

Pre-Curriculum Introduction Session

This session is designed to introduce the facilitator(s) and group members, and set the tone for the sessions to come. In this session, you'll do basic introductions and intention-setting, and you'll establish ground rules.

Lesson Script

Welcome, everyone, to this group that has been designed to teach you about issues of abuse in a supportive, healing environment. This is a space where we'll be sharing a lot about our lives and experiences, so this session is designed to help us get acquainted and set the tone for some serious discussions up ahead. But first, let's do some introductions.

Introductions

Let's go around the room and share our names, one thing we're hoping to learn or experience in this group, and one thing you're maybe more nervous about upon entering into the space.

Icebreaker

Choose an icebreaker from the Icebreaker List.

Ground Rules and Intention-Setting

In this group, we'll be covering a lot of topics: gender, communication, violence, stress, power, and control. These discussions can be intense.

Setting rules about how we want discussion to go is very important. We want to foster an environment of open communication and mutual respect in this space. That said, it's best that we come up with some ground rules for discussion together. I have two that are mandatory:

- **Confidentiality:** *What happens in this space stays in this space—the only exception being if I in my capacity as the facilitator think there is a pressing, imminent, and direct threat to your safety or someone else's safety.*

- **Respect:** Everyone's thoughts and contributions are to be heard, considered, and responded to respectfully. This is not a space for dismissing the ideas and experiences of our peers. As such, we'll use "I" statements, and never "you" statements, which blame and call out others.

Now let's think about other ground rules we can agree on.

Other examples can include:

- Active listening while someone is speaking—not just waiting to talk
- Be mindful of how much space we're taking up in our sharing. Make sure everyone has a chance to contribute their thoughts
- Be open to asking questions and sharing
- Learn from moments of discomfort, rather than avoiding them.
- Give your peers the benefit of the doubt, but be clear when something is hurting you or crossing a boundary.
- Openness and honesty. No deception in this space.

Can we all agree to these rules? (If desired, have all participants sign the group-generated rules as a gesture of good faith.)

- Are there any questions or concerns about the ground rules?
- Are there any questions or concerns about the group?